



Canon DC51

Camera 'n' Corder!

Canon's DC51 is a Mini DVD camcorder with an attractive silver / grey colour tone. It's attractive-looking with softly curved edges. Build quality is also good..

We didn't like the function button being on the side of the body—you have to turn the unit around to see what you're selecting, or turn your head around if you're shooting a subject in front of you. The 5-way joystick is well-placed. If you have long fingers, you'll need to bend your index finger a bit to reach the zoom.

Canon's menu is quite detailed, especially considering the simpler menus on the Panasonic and Samsung camcorders. Despite the extra options, we never once felt overwhelmed—very intuitive. PictBridge support is built in. The zoom is very smooth and focuses quite fast, unlike some of the Samsung camcorders. But it's a measly 10x optical, so you won't be doing

RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7.5
Ergonomics	: 7
IS effectiveness	: 7.5
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 7.5
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 8
Photo Quality	: 7
Audio quality	: 7.5

any long-distance shooting with this. We were unable to focus on an object 14 inches away at a zoom of approximately 6x—not something that plagued the other camcorders. The IS system works well—although with just 10x of zoom, it's not really being tested a lot.

Canon has a good software bundle that includes Roxio MyDVD, Zoom Browser EX5.7 (which allows you to browse, organise and print your still image albums), and even the latest DV WIA drivers—which is basically a newer standard than the traditional TWAIN. There's a small EOS utility as well, which allows you to even use your camera remotely. We noticed most of Canon's suite seemed geared towards still images rather than video—peculiar.

With a 5-megapixel single-CCD image sensor, still image quality on the DC51 was quite good as expected, as was shooting in dimly-lit conditions—mainly due to the immense size of the image sensor chip (1 / 2.7-inch as opposed to the de facto 1 / 6-inch on most consumer models). Noise was nominal, particularly indoors—a good thing considering that this model is predominantly meant for indoor shooting (given its lack of a longer zoom). Maybe Canon could have gone with a smaller megapixel rating and a 3 CCD sensor system to boost indoor shooting. Outdoor video clips were clear, crisp and vibrant, with the soft colour tones that is patent Canon.

At Rs 58,995, the DC51 is costly—more than double the price of its siblings, but it's a good camcorder. We recommend it if you plan on doing a lot of shooting at birthday parties, weekends at pubs with friends, weddings, and so on—basically indoor stuff, which it excels at.

Specifications:

1 / 2.7-inch CCD sensor (5 megapixels); 2.7-inch viewfinder (123,000 pixels); Optical Image Stabilisation (Shift Type); Weight: 480 gm

Canon DC210

Style Meets Functionality

The DC210 challenges the norm as far as colour tones go, and uses a sporty silver grey / dark grey / dark metallic blue. Based on Mini DVD media, the DC210 is sufficiently compact; it never feels large, no matter how small your hands. It's built very well, similar to its elder sibling, the DC230. Design-wise, the power button and the 5-way joystick are well laid out—right under your thumb, making one-handed operation a snap. Similarly, the Record and Photo buttons are conveniently located, and have a nice positive feel.

RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7.5
Ergonomics	: 7
IS effectiveness	: 6
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 6
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 8
Photo Quality	: 5.5
Audio Quality	: 7

Once again the Lithium-ion battery is accessible when the LCD viewfinder is opened—unlike the DC51, there's no one-touch PictBridge support, and no USB port. Canon's provided the same detailed menu as we've seen on their other camcorders; it's excellent, but the number of options will be appreciated by all, and the simplicity of those options will make even newbies feel at ease.

Although the zoom is slow and progressive (a good thing), the DC210 does have a slight issue at the long-end of its zoom—it simply takes too long to focus if the subject happens to be a bit closer. In fact, all the other camcorders—including its Canon siblings—were faster, making us wonder what exactly was causing the problem. While zooming on a subject 10 feet away, the DC210 actually took six to seven seconds to focus properly (this usually takes around four seconds).

The real issue with the DC210 is shooting indoors, that is, in less-than-ideal lighting, where graininess, noise, and colour casts become apparent.

At Rs 18,995, the DC210 is very affordable as far as a camcorder goes. The issue we see is the value/performance trade-off (an ever-present evil). Recommended if you cannot spend any more (it's a great buy for the price)—but it does lose out to the Sony DCR-DVD608E, albeit by a small margin.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD sensor (0.8 Megapixel); 2.7-inch LCD viewfinder (123,000 pixels); Digital (Electronic) Image Stabilisation; Weight: 400 gm

